When Everything Is a Priority

7 questions to make choices when your team is overloaded

When leaders tell me their teams are stretched, I want to understand the choices behind the workload. I work with them to examine competing commitments, the people each depends on and what can actually wait. Before asking the team to work differently, I ask which decision its leaders still need to make.

Christian Lefevre · Managing Partner

THE FIRST MOVE

Name what will give way to the priority.

Seven questions to make a choice

01 Which outcome matters most right now?
Name the result that must improve, not the busiest project.

02 What truly cannot be delayed?
Separate fixed obligations from deadlines we set ourselves.

03 Where does the work compete for capacity?
Check which commitments depend on the same people.

04 What would happen if we paused this?
Name the consequence, who bears it and when it arises.

05 Who can authorise the trade-off?
Resolve competing demands with the relevant sponsors.

06 What will we stop, reduce or postpone?
Specify the work removed and the capacity this releases.

07 What would justify changing our choice?
Set a review date and the evidence that could change it.

Avoid three traps

- **Ranking without removing**
  A shorter priority list changes little if every old commitment remains.
- **Planning around heroics**
  Repeated overtime can hide a capacity gap the plan never resolves.
- **Passing the conflict down**
  Sponsors leave the team to settle conflicting demands.

Make room for one

20 MINUTES / CURRENT WORK

Sort current commitments:

- **Protect**
- **Reduce**
- **Pause or stop**

Choose one change that frees capacity for your main priority. Agree it with the sponsor, tell those affected and set a review date.

IN PRACTICE Three priorities, one Chief Medical Officer

Consider a biotech leadership team scheduling investor meetings and a potential partner's due diligence alongside a critical clinical data review. Each requires the Chief Medical Officer's input. The CEO and CMO identify where her judgment is essential: they protect the data review, delegate preparation of investor materials and agree a narrower first discussion with the potential partner. The priorities remain, but the demands on the CMO become achievable.

FINAL THOUGHT

If leaders do not choose what gives way,
the team will make that choice under pressure.

NEXT NOTE Everyone Wants to Meet You